



“It’s not just about making in India for India, which is a very large market and can pay for better quality now. And it’s no longer like our competitors did 10, 15 years ago, low-cost, low-margin”

Sanjeev Krishan

mobility as a service, infrastructure as a service. I may be a big player, but all these things must finally go to the user. It is not just a good solution; it must also be a good experience. There is a kind of connected society challenge of both centripetally reaching out to the end user and centrifugally enabling them to go out from a human-centric perspective. That’s why we have the payment business, the education business, where all Kendriya Vidyalayas or full states are on our platform. We are the largest issuers in the private sector of Ayushman Bharat identity documents; doctor training, nurse training and AIIMS are also on Hitachi’s platform.

SZ: How does a corporation manage to do so many things?

SK: Of course, we know that Japan has always been at the cutting edge of technology, innovation and R&D. And it’s always been driven by two factors: One is capital availability. That is, when you can monetise your ideas, innovation and technology, you generate more capital. And Japan has been funding a lot of infrastructure development and various projects in India. And partly that’s got to do with the very strong government-to-government connect that India has had with Japan.

The other I would say is the fact that Japan has been agile to embrace shifts in technology. It has adapted very, very quickly. There are many nations that have not adapted to change, particularly technological change, as quickly as many Asian countries have.

SK: The big Japanese corporations continue to do very well in India. But smaller Japanese companies still find it difficult to come to India. Is there anything India can do more?

BK: When a Virgin Atlantic or a British Airways looks at the Indian market, they look at a middle class of 150-200 million, but a consumer company like Panasonic or Hitachi may look at a middle class of 500 million, and a Japanese ramen company may look like Pepsi at a billion people. There are multiple definitions, and this is what is unique about India. How do you get the right market within India? Because it presents itself as a market for everything. So, you don’t look at it as one country and replicate an outside solution—that is one part. But Japanese trading companies are huge umbrellas that bring their own supply chain. It’s about better stakeholder management.

SZ: How does the company manage the natural friction that would arise from this?

BK: Japanese companies in India have sometimes been found to be slower and more expensive. However, there is trust and reliability of technology. Change management meant that as more Japanese giants became global, they needed to draw up a new list to protect image and reputation, which is bigger than what any other mechanism of brand value can create.

SZ: But isn’t that the trend, that when Japanese companies come, they create clusters? For instance, there are dedicated hotels, etc. Has that changed?

BK: A lot has changed. The younger Japanese are bringing their families, their children are going to school here. You know, it’s the familiarity of the language, the understanding of the culture. There are nearly 2,000